

INTRODUCTION

STRENGTHENING YOUR FAMILY DYNASTY

For the past 15 years, our friends—we'll call them the Claytons—have hosted Thanksgiving dinner at their house. We always look forward to it. The tradition began when our kids were still small; Mitchell and Judy invited us and three other families to partake in their annual feast. Every year, my wife, Linda, and I pile in the car with our two children, Savannah and Trevor, and a couple bottles of good wine. When we get to the Claytons', the house is filled with people, laughter and the mouthwatering aroma of the turkey Judy has roasted to perfection yet again. The Claytons have it all—a beautiful home, two great kids, the perfect family and financial security.

At least they *did*, until the year everything fell apart.

Last Thanksgiving, we knew something was wrong the minute we pulled into the driveway. For starters, there weren't any other cars. "What's going on?" Trevor asked. We were all asking ourselves the same question.

I rang the bell and Mitchell came to the door. He looked like he had aged 12 years in 12 months. Linda and I had heard through some friends that he and Judy had been having some marital trouble, but to be perfectly honest, I didn't quite know how bad things had gotten. Judy and Mitchell had what looked to everyone like a wonderful relationship. They'd been married for decades and